Trading Miraa: from School-leaver to Shop-owner in Kenya*

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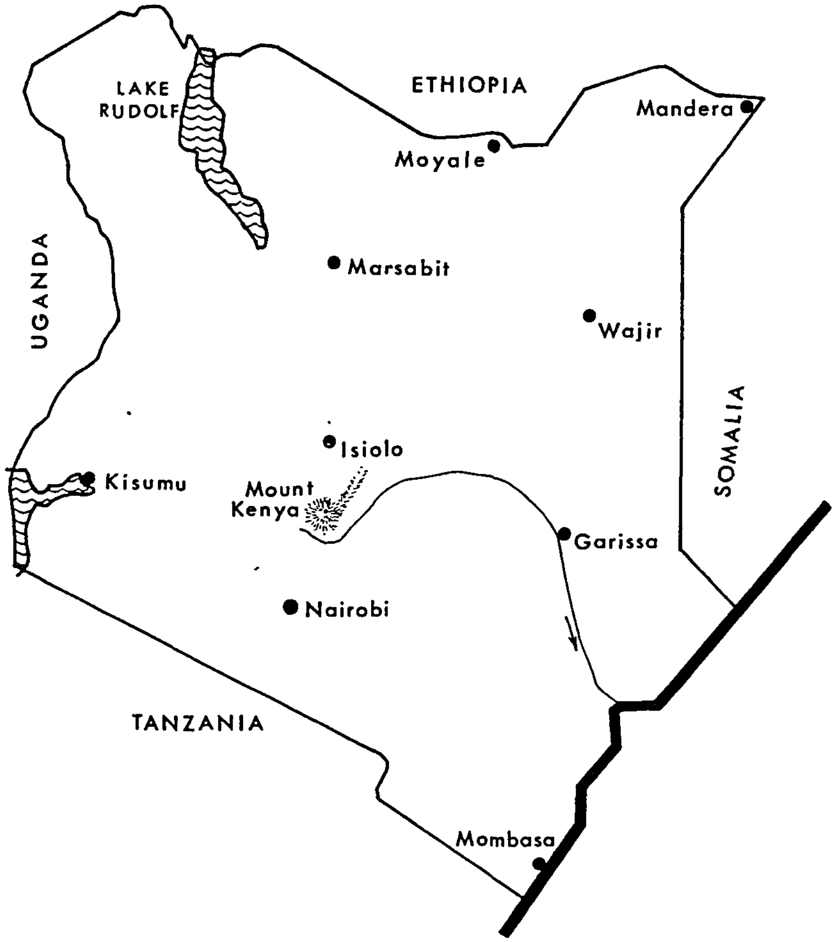
1. Introduction

Miraa (Catha Edulis) is a tree, usually between four and ten metres tall, which grows in various places of East Africa, Ethiopia and Arabia. Young twigs of the tree (15—30 cm) growing directly from the trunk or the branches, are picked every 28 days and sold in bundles. The bark (and on good quality *miraa* also the leaves) are chewed as a stimulant.[1] It is very popular among Moslem people like the pastoral Somali and Borana.

One of the best farming areas, maybe the best in the world,[2] is Nyambeni Hills, north-east of Mount Kenya, inhabited by three sub-tribes of the Kenya Meru: Imenti, Tigania and Igembe (see Maps 1 and 2). To the north-west of this area lies Isiolo, a town with important miraa trading. It is situated on the border between the farming areas of Bantu peoples to the south and the grazing areas of the pastoral peoples to the north (Galla, Somali and Nilotic). The town is the gate to the north both geographically, economically and culturally.

Before independence (1963), Isiolo was dominated by Somali ex-soldiers, who had been given the right to graze on the surrounding areas by the British. Also, many poor Turkana had migrated from south-west of Lake Rudolf to Isiolo. At the beginning of the colonial period, the town area belonged to the Samburu, who still live outside the town and seldom enter except for trading purposes.

During the 1950's Meru people started to move to Isiolo, first in order to find employment with the Somalis, many of whom had at this time



Map 1. Sketch-map of Kenya. Scale 1 :15 000 000.

become very rich in cattle and wealthy traders. The Shifta war (1964—1969), a guerilla campaign for the secession of Northern Kenya carried out by Somalis and Borana, ended with the defeat of the Somali and Borana engaged against the Kenyan government. Almost all who had not been killed ran away from Isiolo in 1969. The cattle trade was almost finished due to the war as most stock had been killed or removed by Kenyan troops. Other economic activities were taken over by Meru people of the Tigania sub-tribe who were quickly urged by a local politician to move in.

The purpose of the present essay is to explain the importance of the *miraa* trade for the economic structure of the Meru town people and for the inter-ethnic relations in Isiolo town. The focus is on what opportunities this trade offers rather than on an analysis of the market.[3] For the Meru traders *miraa* may be seen as an introduction to business life, being a possibility to advance from the ownership of a kiosk to that of cement house shops.

2. The Miraa Trade

Background

Regular trade to Isiolo began in the 1930's parallel with the actual growth of the town. Somali merchants dominated the trade in town and to the north while Igembe and Tigania traders, coming from Lare or Kangeta (see Map 2), transported *miraa* from these markets to Isiolo, often illegally by foot at night. Competition between the traders of these two sub-tribes mounted into open hostilities in the 1940's, causing the Igembe traders to shift to Gachuru and leaving the Isiolo trade to the Tigania traders.[4]

The miraa trade was declared illegal in 1945. From this time on trading became restricted for the private traders and *miraa* had to be smuggled. During 1956—1959, when restricted consumption had become legal, the legal trade was monopolized by a farmers' cooperative, the Meru Traders Society, in order to keep prices high and protect the interests of the farmers against middlemen. When the society went bankrupt in 1959, the trade was legalized for private *miraa* traders and prices went down.

Heavy rains in 1960—1961 made the transportation of *miraa* very difficult, as it had to be transported either on bicycles or by foot. This was reflected in greatly increased prices. The destroyed bridges were still not repaired in 1962, which meant that there was no possibility of road transport to Moyale, Mandera, Marsabit and Wajir (see Map 1). Some of the rich Somali traders in Isiolo then started transporting *miraa* to these places by air. They would purchase *miraa* in Isiolo for 3 KSh per bundle and sell it in these places for 12 KSh per bundle. The aeroplane made three trips per week each time carrying 30,000 bundles.

In Isiolo, the *miraa* trade used to be administered by five Somali merchants, who had licences to buy *miraa* from the Meru Traders Society. They also purchased from the private traders as it was impossible to tell what *miraa* came from the cooperative and what came from these traders.

The Shifta war brought changes in the *miraa* trade. *Miraa* was declared illegal once more in Isiolo and north thereof, as it was useful in the warfare; fighters could go long without food or sleep by chewing *miraa*. Smuggling started again, this time on very tough conditions. As the Meru people generally identified themselves with the new government, there was a social sanction against those who smuggled *miraa* as they were considered to help the enemy. Also, if smugglers were found in the bush, they were shot without warning both by the Shifta and the government soldiers.

The Economy of the Miraa Trade

Miraa is one of the most important cash crops in Meru District and it is probably safe to say that it is the most important one in Nyambeni Hills. Statistics both for production and trading are unreliable as many people try to avoid taxes and other costs involved. It would be a good guess to increase official production figures and trading figures by at least 50 per cent.

Miraa is exported on a large scale to the neighbouring countries of Tanzania, Uganda, Zambia, Zaire, the Sudan and Somalia as well as to Arab countries in the Middle East. Restrictions on consumption have been established recently at least in Somalia and Tanzania. In Somalia, for example, *miraa* consumption is only allowed on Fridays and in Tanzania a total ban on *miraa* was introduced at the beginning of 1974, thus lowering the Kenyan income by officially 1.6 million KSh annyally.[5]

According to the Annual Report from Meru District Agricultural Officer, 1968, the Nyambeni farmers traded *miraa* for about 6.2 million KSh in 1968.[6] From this and earlier Annual Reports one can calculate an average payment per bundle of 0.15—0.17 KSh during 1966—1968 (these are the only years for which the figures seem consistent).

Bernard estimates that *miraa* farmers gained over 2,000 KSh per acre in 1968. This is based on an estimation that only 3,000 acres are grown, which must be a very rough calculation as land fragmentation is great and *miraa* trees grown on a small scale mixed with other kinds of crops. Comparing with coffee growing in Meru District, which gave a return of 1,543 KSh per acre in 1968 (based on figures presented by Bernard, 1972: 122), the return per acre is about 30 per cent higher for *miraa* than for coffee. This is in sharp contrast to Sandberg's statement[7] that the return per acre for *miraa* is about three times that for coffee in Igembe. Even if Sandberg's calculations only involve Igembe and not all of Meru District, the figures should be comparable, provided coffee production per acre in Igembe is similar to the district average. There is no reason to believe that this is not the case.[8] Unfortunately, Sandberg does not tell us how he reached this conclusion.

These different calculations, which are the only ones to be found in the literature as far as can be ascertained, reflect how uncertain production statistics are, a fact that is confirmed by Bernard (p. 130):

> "Because of land fragmentation and a general reluctance to discuss *miraa* earnings, it is difficult to know just how profitable it is. Judging from the demand for *miraa*, there is little doubt that profits are substantial."

His impression that profits from the *miraa* trade are substantial needs to be looked into in further detail here as there has been no serious analysis of this matter.

The better qualities of *miraa,* such as *giza* and *kangeta,* which are particularly strong and good tasting, are packed in *small bundles* of four shoots. Ten of these small bundles are tied together and make up one *bundle.* This is the minimum quantity that is traded. Twenty such bundles make up one *kilo* (approx. one kilogramme), tied in two parts and wrapped in banana leaves to keep fresh. Ten *kilos* are packed together and constitute one *big bundle.*

The production of *miraa* is high and constant from October to May—June. The price is low during this period. The traders buy *giza* of the best quality for about 2 KSh per bundle at a market in Meru. Different kinds of *majani* (the poorest quality) can cost as little as 0.20 KSh while *kangeta* costs 0.75—1.00 KSh per bundle for the traders.

During June—October, when costs are high and production low, it is difficult to find *kangeta* for less than 2 KSh and *giza* for less than 4 KSh for the traders.

These figures are reliable but do not correspond with the calculation of average payment per bundle to the farmer based on official records as presented by Bernard. Even if part of the difference is due to costs for the farmer when trading, this again indicates how unreliable all farming statistics regarding *miraa* are.

When selling to the consumers there are no fix prices except for *giza* which is e.g. 5 KSh per bundle in Isiolo during October—June and about 8 KSh during the rest of the year. A few price examples for the low cost season for the very best brand of *miraa*, are

Isiolo	5 KSh
Garissa	10 KSh
Mombasa	10 KSh
Mandera	20 KSh
Moyale	25 KSh

Miraa is not storeable. This characterizes the trade in that decisions must be made rapidly and the distribution network function smoothly. We can also see from the prices stated above that they are correlated with the distance that the miraa must be transported. The situation encourages the development of a middleman system where the individual farmer becomes exploited. This is elaborated by Sandberg (1969: 11) and is supported by the general opinion in the area. Petty traders in miraa, however, often contact the farmer directly. After negotiating about the price, the buyer brings his people (mainly relatives) to pick for him.

In order to elaborate about the costs involved in trading *miraa* the trade route from the markets in Nyambeni Hills to Isiolo will be examined. Transportation costs per kilo are 1.50 KSh from Kangeta to Isiolo by *matatu* (a kind of taxi). To this should be added different costs for taxes and licences amounting to 2.50 KSh per kilo. The total cost per kilo for transportation etc. becomes 4 KSh or per bundle 0.20 KSh. To this comes one licence for transporting *miraa* from Meru to Isiolo, which costs 180 KSh per year, and one trading licence in Isiolo for 250 KSh per year.

Finally, the rent of one *duka* at the market is generally 70 KSh per month. This cost is often shared by some traders. A typical arrangement is that traders work in pairs so that one goes to buy *miraa* at the Meru markets and one sells at the Isiolo market.

Much *miraa* is then transported further north, especially from the Isiolo market and Gachuru. This trade is mainly in the hands of Somali traders.

Relations of Trade

The *miraa* traders at Isiolo market today are almost invariably from the Tigania sub-tribe. They form a corporate group in certain respects in spite of the fact that competition for customers is often hard. The reason for this will be clear later. They sleep in their *dukas* and help each other with economic expenses if necessary.

Some petty trading in *miraa* is, however, carried out by Borana and Somali women who act as middlemen between the Meru kiosk owners and the Boran and Somali customers. This trade has developed after the Shifta war, when many people were killed or impoverished. The women then started trading *miraa,* thus entering a new, formerly prohibited, sector out of economic necessity. Their trade is often on a very low level; they purchase a few bundles from a Tigania market trader and sell in town or, more often, borrow *miraa* on credit and pay back after the miraa has been sold. Many husbands do not approve of their wives trading *miraa* as it implies a socially too extravert occupation. Therefore, most of the Borana and Somali women who trade *miraa* are not married.

There are only a few cases of women having made large scale business careers in the *miraa* trade. The Meru merchants (without exception males for reasons that will be discussed later) can monopolize major parts of the trade chain, from the producer to the local market in Nyambeni Hills to the markets in Isiolo (for Tigania traders) and Gachuru (for Igembe traders). The majority of the female traders act as middlemen in these places, dominated by the Meru traders. Those who succeed in making a surplus have established their own niche with regular customers, e.g. bringing the *miraa* from the market to some other small place, and add other items like cloth, perfume etc. to the trade.

Transactions with Turkana tribesmen, who have recently also started to consume *miraa,* are direct. Tigania and Turkana call each other "brothers" and have a common myth about their origin. This is often referred to in negotiations, implying a kind of joking relationship.

3. The Internal Structure of the Meru Miraa Trade

All twelve traders with a licence at the Isiolo market are from Tigania. Out of these, seven are from Karama sub-location (in Muthara location). At the time of investigation (in September when prices are high and the volume of the trade is low) they had employed a total of twelve assistants, nine of whom belonged to the same sub-clan. Five of these were classificatory brothers to the licence-holders.

The remaining five traders with a licence also came from Muthara or from Kianjai (both locations in Tigania Division). They were employing five assistants althogether. Three of these were of the same sub-clan, the other two being one Borana and one Turkana.

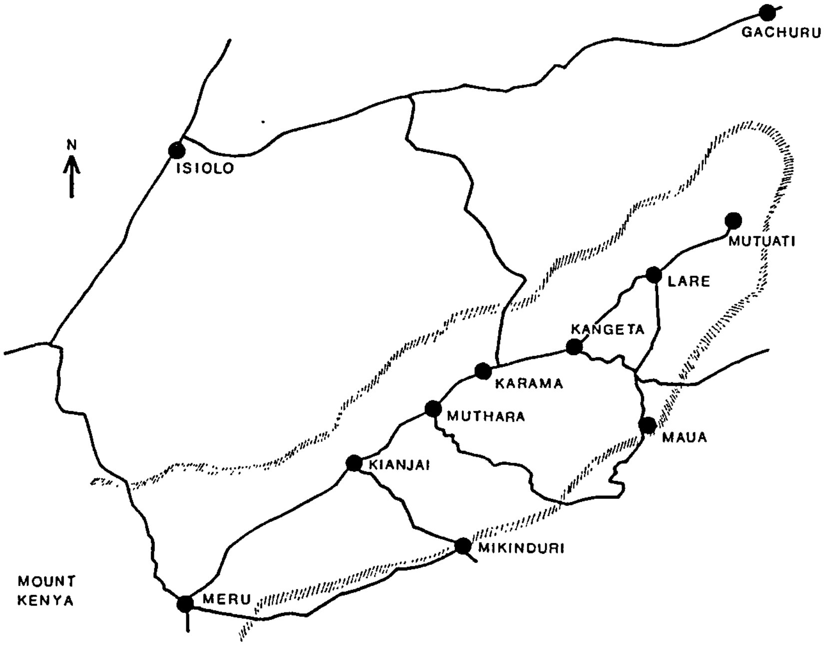
Besides these traders, there were thirteen traders working (officially as assistants) in the other traders' *dukas* without having a trading licence. In all cases but two they were of the same sub-clan as the licence holder.

The first conclusion that can be made is that kinship is an important aspect for a *miraa* trader, being significant even down to a sub-clan level. The second is that assistants have a client-status visavi the licence holders; they are not paid an agreed-upon salary, but their expenses are met and they are given some extra money when the trade is successful. If a trader faces a loss, this is covered by himself only and does not involve the assistants.

The Creation of Patron-Client Relations

Regular traders are, for social reasons, often forced to take on assistants, who can refer to a kinship relation and demand help according to customs. In this respect the traders are a resource with great advantages for assistants-to-be: they are found all over Kenya and their trade implies contacts with many people.

Two major reasons can be distinguished for young Meru males to enter the *miraa* trade. One is the pressure on land in Nyambeni Hills which



Map 2. Sketch-map of Nyambeni Hills. Scale 1:250 000.

leads to land fragmentation and tendencies for a landless class to develop.[9] Landlessness especially strikes younger brothers within a family. The other reason is the general attitude among educated people to prefer white collar jobs to subsistence farming.

The assistants (clients) fall into two distinct categories: those who are primarily interested in entering upon a business career, and those who are looking for other employment. For the last category, working as a *miraa* assistant might be very opportune; one can visit many urban centres in Kenya in search of employment. Furthermore, through the kind of job that trading *miraa* is, one is well informed about what is going on locally. This means good chances to make use of any opportunity in the so-called "informal sector"[10] by hearing about situational possibilities.

What reasons are there then for the first category of assistants not to become regular traders immediately? A general answer to this question is that the traders (patrons) control certain resources. The most important of these are know-how and contacts. As *miraa* is storeable for such a short time (it must be consumed within 3—4 days after harvest), important decisions must be made quickly and because there is so much money involved, they must be made correctly. It is generally considered that it takes one to two years to learn these skills, especially how to offer right prices at the markets in Nyambeni Hills, whom to buy from there and how much *miraa* should be brought to Isiolo.

Other resources that the patrons control, at least during the high cost season (June—October), are linked with economic expenses, like shop-rent, transportation costs and licences apart from capital to invest in the goods.

When the price is low (October to May), a greater number of persons try to make a living out of trading it. They can then afford to buy it cheaply either directly from the producer or from a local middleman at a Meru market, and try their luck to transport it to Isiolo in order to sell it. When prices go up (June to October), such strategy is no longer possible for them, and many temporary traders quit the business.

For these small-scale traders to get started at all, they need the support of a patron who already has a *miraa* business, where they can sell their own *miraa* on a day-to-day contract needing only a starting capital of about 100 KSh. In this way, they avoid having to be registered as *miraa* traders, which means buying a licence, as they are officially assistants to the registered *miraa* businessman.

One Case: Mr. Mugambi

The case of Mr. Mugambi shows a *miraa* trader who has a large business at the Isiolo market. During the period February—July a daily record was kept of what people were working in his *miraa* shop at the market. The record covers the presence of the owner, his permanent and temporary assistants and other traders who rent the right to trade in the shop on a day-to-day basis. The period is selected so as to check particularly what changes occur around the end of May or beginning of June when the high production season ceases and prices go up.

During this time Mr. Mugambi has two permanent assistants, whom he trusts. They take turns to trade at the market and buy *miraa* from the markets in Nyambeni Hills. Up to the beginning of May another assistant is employed temporarily. He stops working on May 9.

In the following table, the average number of persons per day in the shop and the number of independent traders are calculated on a monthly basis (the owner is excluded):

	Average no. of persons	*Of these indep. traders*
February	2.70	1.26
March	2.59	1.15
April	2.18	1.11
May	1.77	1.04
June	1.46	0.79
July	1.22	0.83

There is a clear tendency for the total number of persons working in the shop to go down when the season is over. This is also the case for independent traders, in accordance with the earlier analysis. We can see that when prices go high, there is a reduction in the number of independent traders. They have to adjust to the situation in the new season and invest more money when buying *miraa* in Meru. Those who cannot afford this or who are not willing to risk their capital leave business, at least temporarily.

The average number of persons working in Mr. Mugambi's business goes down from 2.09 per day in February to 0.91 in July.[11] This reflects the other aspect of the new season: the volume of the trade goes down at the same time as prices go up. Mr. Mugambi's business has a turnover of about 500 KSh per day, but with great variations, during both seasons. In the high production season, however, the number of bundles traded are almost ten times the number in the low production season.

Patron-client relations like those of Mr. Mugambi exist between him and his assistants as well as temporary independent traders. They are established via kinship networks on a sub-clan level or within an even closer kinship group. The patron is paid a certain amount of money, normally 2 KSh, per day by the independent trader if the trade has been successful; in case it has failed the patron trader will get no pay until later. For the patron the agreement means a certain supplementary income during the seasons when the price is low, the traded volume of *miraa* high and the net income tends to go down. As the traded volume during this season is increased about ten times, the impact of the trade of his clients is reduced with the high demand; the patron may sell a sufficient volume anyway.

4. Business Careers

The careers of *miraa* traders and the different strategies involved may be discussed in relation to the variables "size of purchased stock" and "transportation distance". In general terms, an increase in any of the variables implies greater risks but also possibly greater returns.

When the purchased stock of *miraa* exceeds a minimum that the trader can be almost sure of selling, the probability that the *miraa* will go bad before he has sold it increases. The larger amount he purchases at one point of time, the larger is the probable amount of wasted *miraa*. At the same time, if this part of the stock can be reduced by trading it, the profit will rise quickly. The risk involved with this variable increases continuously with the volume; in the beginning (after the "threshold") fairly linearly.

The transportation distance implies risks connected with actual choices of markets for trading the *miraa* and travelling time, which reduces the possible time for trading. The most decisive factor is the choice of the trading place; is there a sufficient demand and will other traders choose other places? Such questions account for great fluctuations in the risk due to travelling distance. Transportation costs should not be forgotten, though they are matched by increased prices.

Both variables involve particular know-how about the *miraa* trade. It is, for example, important to be among the first to hear about a high demand for *miraa* in one place. With such knowledge the second variable may be controlled and only the first must be considered.

The combination of the two variables "size of purchased stock" and "transportation distance" expresses a total risk involved in the trading of *miraa*.

A few traders try to limit this risk by selling in several different places. They have a number of shops at increasing distances from Nyambeni

Hills; e.g. one in Isiolo, one in Wamba, one in Marsabit and one in Moyale. When the miraa is beginning to seem old to the Isiolo customers, it is transported to Wamba, eventually transported to Marsabit, etc. This strategy has only limited success, as other traders may bring the *miraa* directly to these places. They are, however, few and miss deliveries when they are short of money. Such situations may be exploited by rushing half-old *miraa* to a place where the demand is great. With such behaviour a trader can sell a portion of his stock which he would otherwise have to throw away, thus making a huge profit.

People engaged in *miraa* trading fall in three categories: those who employ a "safe" strategy with low return, those who trade as a supplement to other income during the low cost season, and those who "gamble" with possible high returns.

The ambition of the first category is to make a permanent living out of the *miraa* trade. The majority of these traders are old men who have been in the same business for a long time, in some cases since the 1940's. They purchase small amounts at the markets in Nyambeni Hills transporting them a relatively short distance and selling almost the whole stock of each delivery, leaving them with a net profit of 400—700 KSh per month. They hardly accumulate any capital and certainly not more than is needed to invest in a small *duka*.

The second category is made up of people who can only afford to invest in *miraa* stock during the low cost season and who do not accumulate enough capital to continue the trade when costs go up. They have a client-relation to regular traders; they rent the right to use these traders' shops on a daily basis, being officially assistants to the ordinary shop-owners. These fluctuations are illustrated in the case of Mr. Mugambi.

The third category, the "gamblers", are people who take great chances by investing all the money they can possibly get together in one large stock which, if sold altogether, will give them a high profit.

In order to demonstrate the amount of money and the possibilities of profit-making, the following exercise is made. For a trader in Isiolo with a high turnover, one typical delivery may consist of 50 big bundles. Supposing that this is *miraa* of good quality, and that one delivery is made per week, the costs may be roughly:

Purchasing	10,000 KSh
Fees ("customs")	2,025 KSh
Transportation	1,000 KSh
Licences	10 KSh
Rent of *duka*	20 KSh
Salaries (two assistants)	200 KSh
	13,255 KSh

If every bundle is sold at 3 KSh, this means a gross income of 30,000 KSh and a net of 26,745 KSh.

As *miraa* is storeable for only up to four days after the harvest,[12] the calculation is not realistic. All bundles that have not been sold after this period must be thrown away. From the calculations we see that, unless half the delivery is sold, the trader must face a loss, provided he has no earlier losses to make up for.

The "Gambling" Miraa Traders

The major reason given by newcomers for trying the *miraa* trade is that they have nothing to do anyway, so they might as well try to enter business. The *miraa* trade is then one out of a few alternatives. Many school-leavers are unable to find employment in Kenya and, as they almost invariably value white-collar jobs higher than subsistence farming on a small scale (see p. 35), they try other ways of making a living. Trading in *miraa* is one way to stay in town fulfilling an "urbanism" ideology, and to join a peer group who are living a life that they regard as adventurous. The young *miraa* traders may be typical school-leavers in that they can spend a few years trying their luck in trade or searching for employment before they return home to a small piece of land on which they will barely be able to make a living. They are often found in the third category above, among the "gambling" *miraa* traders.

The career of Mr. Muriithi may be typical of the category of traders who take great risks. He entered the *miraa* business in 1971 when he raised money by buying a leopard skin for false money,[13] smuggling it to Isiolo and trading it there. For the money he immediately bought *miraa* at Kangeta, transported it to Isiolo and managed to sell all of it with a considerable profit. About one year later he went completely bankrupt after having failed to sell three consecutive deliveries of *miraa*, but he managed to accumulate new capital, this time by making use of a thorough knowledge of the trade whereby he got another involuntary credit, this time from a *miraa* middleman. Some time after that he tried to "make big money" on hearing a rumour that deliveries had been very poor to a town far north in Kenya. He rented a car, loaded it with *miraa* and took off. On his arrival, he tried to smuggle the *miraa* into the town without paying cess but was caught, and all his *miraa* was confiscated until he had paid a severe fine. As Mr. Muriithi was unable to put forth the requested sum, the whole load of *miraa* dried and he had to remain for two weeks in this northern town completely without money until the police gave him some petrol and a spare part for the rented car, which had broken down.

The "gambling" traders can be said to dominate the trade in that they account for the major turnover. The category is significant in several respects.

Firstly, they are in business for a short period, or possibly a few short periods, of a couple of years. They start as assistants with a regular trader in order to learn "the tricks of the trade", turning to trade during a low-cost season.

Secondly, their ambition is not to make a permanent living out of the *miraa* trade but to accumulate money quickly in order to start other retail business on a large scale sufficient for a family to live on, e.g. preferably with a proper stock of a variety of food and household items sold in a cement stone house or the ambition is to save money to pay bridewealth (about 2,000 KSh or 5 cows).

Thirdly, these "high-risk" *miraa* traders are not only relatives on a clan or even sub-clan level (see section 3 above), but also of the same age-set belonging to the same age-class of Older Warriors.[14] They are unmarried men who travel from home in order to trade. Thus they move over large parts of Kenya exploiting their networks in search of an economic niche that might be sufficient to make a living from. Common concensus in Meru community is that trading in *miraa* is not quite decent. This aspect is strongly recognized by many *miraa* traders who argue that it is exciting and that many good friends (i.e. members of the same age-set) are involved. Without pushing a comparison too far one can note that there are similarities between the role these unmarried men are ascribed and the one of the Old Warriors in traditional society.

5. Summary

The *miraa* trade, though very little studied, is an important economic activity not only regionally but also on a national level. The purpose of the present paper has been to establish some basic economic and structural features of the trade in order to understand the context in which the trader acts. It has been possible to distinguish three different kinds of strategies from the *miraa* traders' points of view, depending on his preparedness to take risks, which in turn is depending on the ambitions and skills that he has. A dominant group is made up of not yet married men, who are prepared to take great risks for the possibility of accumulating enough capital to invest in a brideprice and/or other business activities than trading *miraa,* like retail trading.

NOTES

* This article is based on fieldwork carried out in Kenya in 1972—74.

1. The poison stimulates the central nervous system but has a slow effect. It normally takes at least a few hours to feel the effects, even though this varies greatly with different qualities. The drug contains three alkaloids: cathine, cathidine and cathinine, apart from other substances. Cathine is d-norisoephedrine, a powerful exciter of the nervous system. See Verdcourt & Trump and W. Köhler.
2. Bernard p. 130.
3. An analysis of this will be presented in A. Hjorth: *Ethnicity and Economy in a Savannah Town* (forthcoming).
4. This makes Isiolo the only *miraa* market in Kenya where Igembe traders do not outnumber the Tigania traders.
5. Sources: a radio broadcast on Mogadiscio Radio and Sunday Nation April 7, 1974.
6. See Bernard, p. 131. The official figure is 309,640 pounds.
7. A. Sandberg, 1969, p. iii, note 22.
8. From Bernard pp. 119—120 it appears that coffee production in Igembe is rather above than below the average for the whole district.
9. See e.g. Sandberg (1971) p. 75.
10. The "informal sector" includes such cash-giving activities as do not show in official statistics, i.e. work other than formal employment. This covers a wide range of activities, often in the service-sector and sometimes with an illegal touch. The topic has been thoroughly debated with a climax in the ILO-report (*Employment, Incomes and Equality: a strategy for increasing pro-*

ductive employment in Kenya, ILO, Geneva, 1972) and Colin Leys's criticism of the use of the term "informal sector" as presented in the ILO-report ("Interpreting African under-development: reflections on the ILO Report on Employment, Incomes and Equality in Kenya", *African Affairs 72* (289) October 1973).

11. The monthly figures beginning with February are: 2.09, 1.63, 2.03, 1.46, 0.85, and 0.91.
12. Many *miraa* traders in places like Mombasa have invested in refrigerators, and they claim that this makes storing for one week possible. The price on *miraa* stored in a refrigerator is raised about 0.10 KSh per bundle.
13. Trading in wild life trophies is illegal in Kenya.
14. Meru have an age-class system common for many East African people. Members of one age-set are by definition relatives, as initiation takes place within each sub-clan, and also friends, as close friendship is an ascribed attribute of members of any one age-set.

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